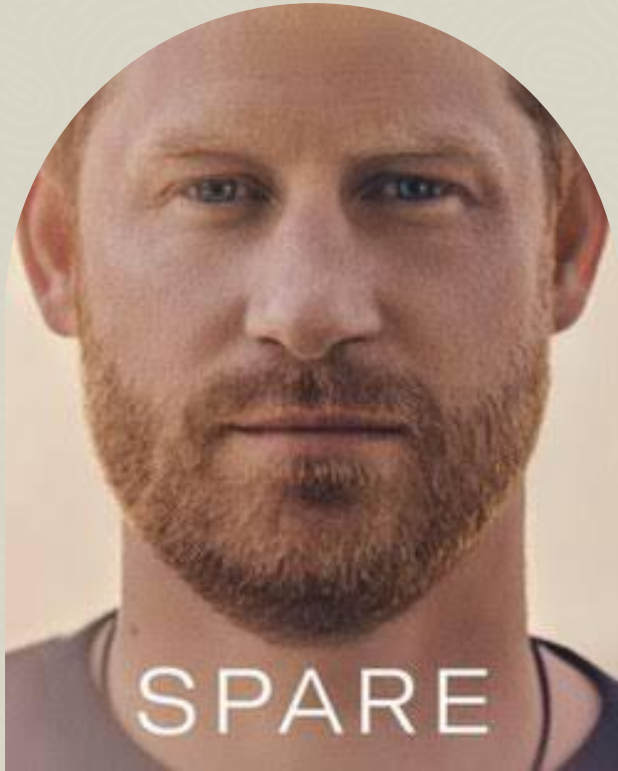




Part 1: Memoirs

Your story....

What is a memoir?

A memoir is a true story about someone's life.

But a memoir isn't:

- Your entire life story
- A list of everything that has happened to you
- An autobiography
- Just a collection of facts

Instead, a memoir focuses on meaningful experiences.

Memoirs ask:

- What happened to me?
- How did it affect me?
- What did I learn, realize, lose, gain, or become?



What is a memoir?

Memoirs are usually:

- Personal: the writer is part of the story
- Focused: they zoom in on particular experiences
- Reflective: they explore what an experience meant
- Selective: they don't tell everything that happened
- Meaningful: they reveal something about the writer

Memoir isn't just what happened. It's why what happened matters.



MEMOIR $\neq$ AUTOBIOGRAPHY

AUTOBIOGRAPHY

"Here is my life story."

May cover:

- Childhood
- School
- Family
- Career
- Major accomplishments
- Important events

MEMOIR

"Here is a story from my life that means something."

Usually focuses on:

- A particular experience
- A relationship
- A period of change
- A challenge
- A realization
- A moment that shaped the writer

Autobiography = the whole journey

Memoir = one meaningful part of the
journey

A Memoir Doesn't Have To Be A Huge Story

You don't need to have:

- Climbed Mount Everest, survived a shipwreck, won a championship, traveled around the world

Those are cool stories, but they aren't relatable to the ordinary person.

A memoir can come from something ordinary.

- A bus ride.
- A conversation.
- A birthday.
- A mistake.
- A walk home.
- A first day.
- A goodbye.



The question isn't: "Was this the
most exciting thing that ever
happened to me?"

The question is: "Did this moment
mean something to me?"

Memoirists Zoom In

Imagine your life is a movie. You could make a movie about your entire life, but a memoirist uses the zoom lens.

- Instead of: "I've played soccer since I was six."
 - Zoom in: The first game I almost quit.
- Instead of: "My family moved when I was young."
 - Zoom in: The last night in my old bedroom.
- Instead of: "I've always loved my grandmother."
 - Zoom in: The afternoon she taught me her recipe.

Small moment → Big meaning



Look Beneath The Event

A memoir has two layers.

WHAT HAPPENED?

The actual event.

WHAT IT MEANT?

The deeper significance.

For example:

What happened: I didn't make the team.

What it meant: I learned that failure didn't mean I had to quit.



Memoirists Look Back

When we tell a story from our lives, we can see things that we couldn't necessarily see while they were happening.

A memoirist asks:

- What did I think then?
- What do I think now?
- What did I understand then?
- What do I understand now?
- How did this experience change me?
- This is called reflection.



One Way to Think About Memoirs

THEN

What did I believe?

What did I want?

What was I afraid of?

How did I see the situation?

Who was I?

NOW

What do I believe now?

What do I understand now?

What am I no longer afraid of?

How do I see it differently?

Who did I become?

A meaningful memoir often contains
a shift:

I thought _____.

Then _____ happened.

Now I understand _____.

Look For The Crossroad

A crossroad is a moment when something changes.

It might be:

- A decision
- A discovery
- A mistake
- A loss
- A success
- A conversation
- A realization
- A new beginning
- An ending

Before this
moment...

After this
moment...

Key Aspects About Memoirs

Good memoir writers choose details that help the reader feel or understand the experience.

Memoirs use specific details

No one else can tell your story exactly like you

Memoirs help us understand identity

YOU DON'T NEED AN EXTRAORDINARY LIFE TO HAVE AN
EXTRAORDINARY STORY.



Before You Choose Your Story...

Ask yourself:

- What moment do I keep thinking about?
- What experience changed something for me?
- What person influenced who I became?
- What challenge taught me something?
- What did I once believe that I don't believe anymore?
- What is a small moment with a big meaning?
- What story could only I tell?



Step One:
Decide some possible memoir topics
Assignment on Google Classroom



Part 2: Illustrated 6 Word Memoirs

Your smaller story & illustration....

What Is a Six-Word Memoir?

A six-word memoir tells a true story about you in exactly six words.

The challenge is that you have an entire life of experiences, but only six words, so that means every word matters.

You don't have to explain everything. You want your reader to wonder, infer, and think.



Six Words Can Tell a Story

You could have six random words:

- Soccer. Friends. School. Dog. Summer. Music.

That's six words, but it doesn't really tell us a story.

Instead:

- Moved away. Made friends. Found home.

Now we can imagine a story.

I failed. I tried.
I succeeded.

Or:

Lost something.
Found
something.
Became
different.

Memoir = More Than What Happened

A strong memoir isn't just about an event, it's about the meaning behind the event.

Think about: **EVENT** → **EXPERIENCE** → **MEANING**

For example:

First day of school.

- is an event.

But:

New school. New friends. New me.

- tells us something about the experience and its meaning.



Your Story Is a Journey

Throughout LC9, we'll read stories about people who go on journeys.

Some journeys are:

Physical / Emotional / Social / Intellectual / Personal

And often, the character who begins the story is not the same person who ends it.

Think: WHO WAS I? → WHAT HAPPENED? → WHO DID I BECOME?



Your Six Words = A Tiny Journey

Your memoir can capture a moment somewhere along your journey.

You might write about:

- BEFORE: Who you were before something happened
- DURING: A challenge, experience, or turning point
- AFTER: How the experience changed you



What Experiences Could You Write About

A FIRST

- First friend
- First performance
- First day somewhere new
- First major accomplishment

A CHANGE

- Moving
- Growing up
- Changing schools
- Changing friendships
- Discovering a new interest

What Experiences Could You Write About

A CHALLENGE

- Failure
- Fear
- Conflict
- A difficult decision
- Something you had to overcome

A PERSON

- Someone who changed you
- Someone you lost
- Someone who helped you
- Someone you became because of

A DISCOVERY

- Something you learned
- Something you realized
- Something you didn't understand before

You Don't Have to Share Everything

Your story belongs to you, so you decide what you're comfortable sharing.

Your memoir can be:

- Deep
- Funny
- Serious
- Hopeful
- Bittersweet
- Mysterious
- Simple

You do not need to write about your most painful or private experience. Choose a story that is meaningful to you, whatever that may be.

The Face

For your assignment, you are writing & illustrating. You will draw half of a face, the other half will be your six-word memoir. Think about how the visual and the words can work together.

Your drawing might represent:

- Your interests
- Your personality
- Your memories
- Your family
- Your experiences
- Your goals
- Your challenges
- Your identity

Because you only have 6 words,
The words + image = YOU



Don't Just Draw a Portrait

Instead of asking: "What do I look like?"

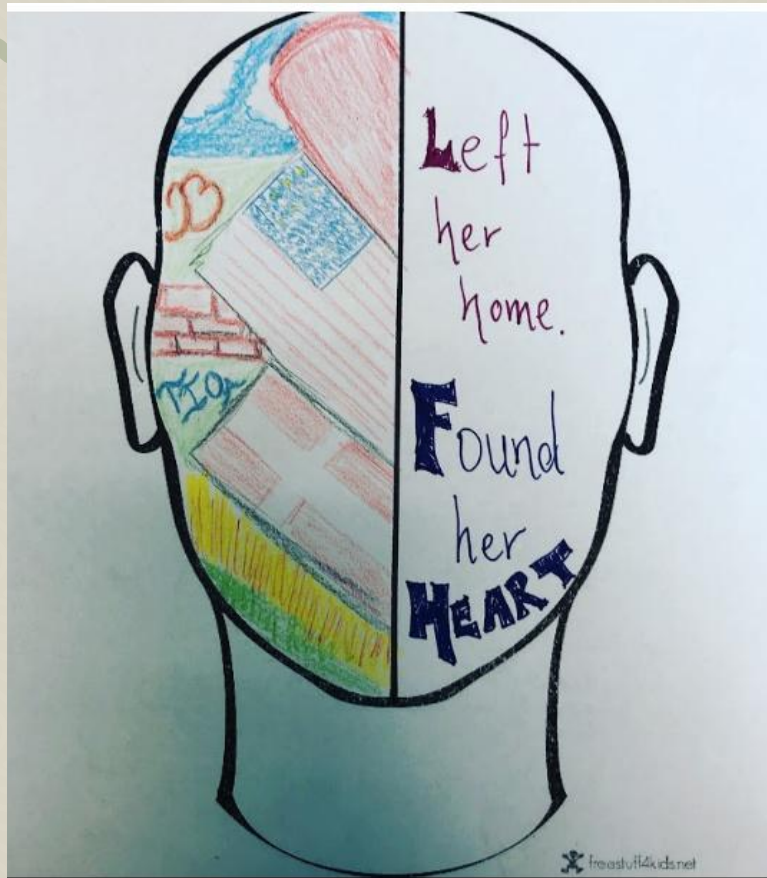
Ask: "What makes me who I am?"

Your visual could include: Music / Books / Sports / Nature / Art / Animals /
Places / People / Goals / Memories

Use symbolism.

- A drawing doesn't have to literally illustrate every word.





When Writing – Revision Matters

Your first six words probably won't be your final six words.

Try writing at least three versions.

Version 1: Write the story simply.

Version 2: Replace ordinary words with stronger ones.

Version 3: Make the reader wonder.



When Writing – Count Carefully

A six-word memoir means SIX WORDS.

For example:

I / finally / learned / to / let / go = 6 words

- Contractions count as one word.
- Hyphenated words can count as one word.
- Punctuation doesn't count as a word.



Step Two:
Create your 6 word memoir
& illustration